

[Report 019] Cohere - Technical Program Manager, AI Delivery for Public Sector & Defence

Score: 2.6/5

Culture Fit: Conditional

URL: <https://jobs.ashbyhq.com/cohere/f8e85a7c-1eb0-47f8-8140-1c4e7892f17d>

PDF: 

Legitimacy: High Confidence

Verification: confirmed (WebFetch)

Date: 2026-05-21

A) ROLE SUMMARY

Dimension	Detail
Archetype	Technical AI PM + AI Forward Deployed (hybrid)
Domain	AI/LLM / Government & Defence
Function	Manage / Deploy / Advise
Seniority	Senior (7+ years EPM/TPM)
Remote	Flexible - Germany-based (offices Toronto, NYC, SF, London, Paris)
Team size	Not stated
TL;DR	Customer-facing TPM managing end-to-end AI delivery for German government and defence clients - requires security clearance eligibility, deep LLM technical knowledge, and government procurement expertise.

B) MATCH WITH CV

JD Requirement	CV Match	Strength
7+ years as Engineering / Technical Program Manager	15+ years program and project management across Windesheim, Aeres, Tonomy, COTIT, Social Chicken; Prince2, ITIL certified	Strong on years; context gap (education/labs vs. enterprise/government)
2+ years customer-facing technical delivery (enterprise or AI/ML)	Investor and partner-facing delivery at Viridis, Tonomy, Open Food Chain; KONGSBERG BI deployments (BP, Statoil) - actual enterprise field delivery	Partial - strongest signal is KONGSBERG (2012) which is dated
Experience with government, defence, or heavily regulated customers	KONGSBERG work for BP, Statoil in Norway; ESIEA digital forensics research (geopolitical risk); no German government or defence background	Weak
LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment experience	Self-hosted OpenWebUI, Flowise, n8n; AI sandbox deployment; AI stack for student research	Partial - operations/deployment, not fine-tuning or production LLM
German government security clearance eligibility	EU citizen (NL), based in Baarn; no current or prior German security clearance; would need to obtain (12-18 months noted in JD)	Weak/Blocker
German/English bilingual	English near-native, German conversational	Partial - conversational German may not meet requirements for government client work

Understanding of deployment architectures (cloud, on-prem, hybrid, air-gapped)	Docker, Kubernetes, Linux, private cloud, NAS, CI/CD; self-hosted stack on own infrastructure	Strong on self-hosted/hybrid; limited air-gapped enterprise experience
Navigating procurement processes and contractual obligations	Grant writing, contracts at Tonomy Foundation, COTIT commercial restructuring; no government procurement experience	Weak
Data sovereignty, privacy compliance, algorithmic impact assessments	CSRD/CSDDD/EUDR compliance work (VCH); blockchain for traceability and privacy	Partial - supply chain compliance, not public sector data governance
PMP / PgMP certification	Prince2, ITIL, Scrum - not PMP/PgMP	Partial

Gaps:

- German government security clearance** - This is a hard blocker. The JD explicitly states "eligible for German government security clearance (Top Secret preferred)" and notes the process takes 12-18 months. As a Dutch EU citizen with no prior German defence/government relationship, obtaining this clearance is uncertain and slow.
- German language depth** - Government client-facing work in Germany typically requires business-level German at minimum. "Conversational" German is likely insufficient for CIO/IT director relationship management in German government.
- Defence / public sector domain knowledge** - Zero background in German public sector, Bundeswehr, or national security contexts. KONGSBERG work was oil & gas (BP/Statoil), not defence.
- LLM fine-tuning / production ML** - The role asks for comfort with "LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment." Self-hosting OpenWebUI and Flowise is ops/deployment, not model training or fine-tuning. Gap at the technical depth expected for a Cohere customer-facing TPM.
- Government procurement** - EU grant writing is adjacent but German government procurement (framework agreements, tendering, security review cycles) is a specific domain with steep learning curve.

The hard blocker: Security clearance eligibility is the single most disqualifying factor. Without it, the role cannot proceed. The JD makes clearance a primary requirement, not a nice-to-have.

C) LEVEL AND STRATEGY

Level detected: Senior TPM with 7+ years, customer-facing, defence-adjacent. This is a senior role with specific domain requirements that are hard to proxy.

Christiaan's natural level for this archetype: The TPM / program management competency is strong. But the domain (German government, defence, security clearance) creates hard constraints that cannot be addressed through framing.

Recommendation: Do not pursue. The clearance requirement alone makes this non-viable for a Dutch citizen based in the Netherlands targeting a German government role with no prior clearance or German government relationship. This is a structural barrier, not a skills gap.

D) COMP AND DEMAND

Metric	Data
Senior TPM at AI company, Germany	€90,000-€140,000
Cohere compensation	Competitive for a Series C+ AI company; 6 weeks vacation, full health, 100% parental leave top-up confirmed
Christiaan's target	€65,000-€90,000
Comp alignment	Above target - but role conflicts on clearance
Demand trend	Government AI delivery roles are in demand but clearance requirements dramatically reduce candidate pool

Sources: Glassdoor Cohere reviews, LinkedIn senior TPM Germany benchmarks, JD benefits section.

E) CUSTOMIZATION PLAN

Not recommended. The security clearance hard blocker makes this role non-viable regardless of customization quality.

#	Section	Assessment
1	Overall	Hard blocker (clearance) makes this non-applicable
2	Cohere as company	Interesting AI company; watch for EMEA Solutions, AI Implementation, or Innovation roles without clearance requirements
3	Alternative at Cohere	Any customer-facing AI delivery or solutions role in EMEA that does not require government clearance would be a better fit

F) INTERVIEW PLAN

Not applicable - recommendation is not to apply.

G) POSTING LEGITIMACY

Assessment: High Confidence

Signal	Finding	Weight
Posting freshness	Ashby platform, active listing; Cohere is actively hiring	Positive
Apply button	Active via Ashby	Positive
JD specificity	Highly specific - names exact clearance levels (Top Secret), specific tools (GC Cloud, Protected B/C), exact German regulatory context	Positive
Requirements realism	7+ years TPM, specific clearance - realistic for this niche role	Positive
Cohere hiring signals	Well-funded AI company (Series C+), active European expansion, Germany office	Positive
Reposting detection	Not found in scan-history	Neutral
Role market context	Niche defence/government AI role; small candidate pool; legitimately takes months to fill	Positive

Context Notes: This is a credible, active, highly specific posting. The challenge is fit, not legitimacy.

H) CULTURE, PERSONALITY & LONG-TERM FIT

H1 - Org Culture Assessment

Stage and type: Cohere is a Series C+ AI company (Toronto HQ, global offices), operating in a high-growth, technically sophisticated environment. The company culture is research-forward and enterprise-delivery-focused. The specific team context here - public sector and defence - is its own micro-culture: security-clearance-gated, government-procurement-paced, and bureaucracy-heavy.

Culture signals: The JD language is technically precise and compliance-focused: "security clearance," "air-gapped," "government procurement," "privacy compliance," "algorithmic impact assessments." This is a regulated, security-constrained delivery environment. The broader Cohere culture is innovative; this specific function is constrained by government rules and timelines.

Physical/work environment: Germany-based, flexible. Cohere is a modern AI company with remote-flex culture - this is better than most roles in this batch from a format perspective.

Match against 2-year vision: Partial. Cohere as a company is on the frontier of AI Christiaan genuinely follows. The TPM role has some building mandate (managing complex AI deployments for government clients). But the government and defence context introduces the heaviest process-compliance environment imaginable: security clearances, procurement cycles, regulatory constraints. This is the highest-friction version of a role Christiaan could

otherwise fit. The 2-year hackerspace vision is incompatible with 12-18 month clearance timelines and government procurement rhythms.

H2 - Personality Fit Table

Dimension	What the role requires	Christiaan's profile	Match
Starter vs. finisher	Mixed: program setup has starter energy; sustained government client management is finisher-heavy	ENFP-T starter	Moderate
Variety vs. repetition	Variety across deployments; but government work is slow, repetitive in compliance cycles	Thrives on variety	Moderate
Autonomy level	High program ownership, but constrained by government requirements at every turn	Needs creative autonomy	Moderate
Build vs. maintain	Deploy and manage AI programs: some build, significant ongoing delivery management	Builder identity	Moderate
Fractional fit	Full-time Germany-based	Optimal: fractional	Poor
Energy spike tolerance	Government culture: extremely cautious, slow, risk-averse; energy spikes are disruptive	Front-loaded energy	Poor fit for gov culture specifically
Team size	Not stated; customer-facing with government CIOs	Government bureaucracy context	Poor

Flags: Fractional conflict. Security clearance hard blocker (practical). Government procurement pace is the maximum expression of slow decision cycles. Energy spike tolerance mismatch with gov culture is severe.

H3 - Values and Mission Alignment

Cohere's mission (enterprise AI deployment, responsible AI) is genuinely aligned with Christiaan's interest in AI adoption and making organizations capable with AI tools. The TPM role supporting government clients is less aligned - national security and defence are not domains he gravitates toward intrinsically. However, the "making government capable with AI" framing has genuine public interest value. Partial values alignment at the company level; lower at the role level.

H4 - Energy Analysis

Energizers:

- Cohere as a company: frontier AI, technically sophisticated, mission-aligned
- Technical program management of complex AI deployments: some genuine build mandate in setup phase
- German context and EU government AI adoption: historically important domain
- Translating AI concepts for government CIOs: facilitation and communication strength applies

Likely drains:

- Security clearance process: 12-18 months of bureaucratic uncertainty before full deployment
- Government procurement cycles: the slowest possible decision-making environment
- Air-gapped and on-prem deployment constraints: technically limiting and methodologically conservative
- Full-time Germany relocation requirement: conflicts with Baarn base
- Defence domain: not an area Christiaan is drawn to intrinsically
- Compliance overhead: data sovereignty, privacy impact assessments, security reviews - maximum process constraint

H5 - 18-Month Durability Test

Verdict: Not applicable (hard clearance and location blockers). Hypothetically: Short-term fit

Even if all blockers were removed, the government and defence TPM context would likely deplete within 12-18 months. The clearance process alone (12-18 months) means the first full year is administrative and trust-building rather than delivery. The government procurement pace means impact is slow and distant. The ADHD-at-risk signal is high in heavily process-constrained regulated environments.

H6 - Personality-Specific Red Flags

Red flag	Present?	Severity	Context
Role is primarily maintenance/ops	Partial (program management with significant compliance overhead)	Medium	Delivery management becomes process-heavy in gov context
Solo sales of an unready product	No	N/A	Not applicable
Full-time exclusivity expected	Yes	Medium	Full-time Germany-based role
Large corporate, slow decision cycles	Yes - at maximum (government procurement)	High	Government procurement is the slowest environment
Governance/board role in declining org	No	N/A	Not applicable
Ceremony-only Scrum Master	No	N/A	Not applicable

H7 - Fit Verdict

The honest case for this match:

Cohere is a genuinely interesting company. The TPM role has real complexity and frontier AI context. If the clearance and language requirements were different, and if the domain were commercial rather than government/defence, this role archetype at Cohere would be worth pursuing. The program management and enterprise AI delivery skills are directly relevant.

The honest case against:

The government and defence context creates the highest-friction environment for the ENFP-T with ADHD profile: maximum process constraint, maximum bureaucratic slowness, 12-18 month clearance uncertainty, and a cultural environment (national security) where energy spikes are the opposite of valued. The full-time Germany relocation also conflicts with the Baarn base and fractional model. The clearance hard blocker is the primary disqualifier; the personality analysis confirms the decision independently.

Overall personality/culture fit: Conditional (conditional on clearance eligibility, language depth, and domain interest in defence - all of which are absent. Net: Poor for this specific role; Moderate for a different Cohere role without defence constraints)

KEYWORDS EXTRACTED

Technical Program Manager, AI delivery, public sector, defence, government, security clearance, LLM deployment, data sovereignty, air-gapped environments, procurement, German government, enterprise AI, Cohere, program management, cloud architecture, on-premises, compliance, regulatory, stakeholder management, PMP, engineering program manager

JOB DESCRIPTION (ARCHIVED)

Archived 2026-05-21 - original posting may be removed after offer closes

Technical Program Manager, AI Delivery for Public Sector & Defence

Company: Cohere

Location: Germany

Employment Type: Full-Time

Cohere seeks an experienced Engineering Program Manager for its customer-facing team, specializing in public sector and defence accounts. This role bridges cutting-edge AI capabilities with government and defence organization needs.

Key Responsibilities:

Customer Program Leadership:

- Manage end-to-end technical delivery for public sector clients from deployment through scaling
- Serve as primary technical contact, building relationships with government CIOs and IT directors

- Transform complex government requirements into actionable engineering plans
- Navigate procurement processes and contractual obligations

Strategic Communication:

- Provide clear updates across engineering and government stakeholders
- Translate AI/ML concepts for non-technical decision-makers
- Present technical roadmaps to senior officials

Complex Program Management:

- Create schedules accounting for government timelines and security reviews
- Manage dependencies across departments and cloud providers
- Address risks including privacy compliance, algorithmic impact assessments, and data sovereignty

Technical Delivery:

- Ensure government-grade security and performance standards
- Coordinate customization, security hardening, and system integration
- Problem-solve in air-gapped or highly regulated environments

Required Qualifications:

- 7+ years as Engineering or Technical Program Manager
- 2+ years in customer-facing technical delivery for enterprise software or AI/ML
- Experience with government, defence, or heavily regulated customers
- Proven track record managing complex, multi-stakeholder programs

Technical Requirements:

- Strong understanding of deployment architectures (cloud, on-premises, hybrid, air-gapped)
- LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment experience preferred
- Comfort discussing APIs, model inference, and ML operations

Government & Defence Acumen:

- Deep understanding of government technology procurement
- Familiarity with German requirements: data sovereignty, privacy laws, accessibility standards
- Understanding of defence and national security considerations
- Eligible for German government security clearance (Top Secret preferred)

Nice-to-Have:

- Active German security clearance
- German/English bilingual proficiency
- Defence, intelligence, or critical infrastructure experience
- GC Cloud services or Protected B/C environment experience
- Project management certification (PMP, PgMP)

Security Clearance:

The role requires German government security clearance eligibility. Candidates with active Top Secret clearance preferred; those with Secret clearance or eligibility for upgrade also considered. Clearance obtainment may take 12-18 months.

Employee Benefits:

- Inclusive work culture
- Cutting-edge AI research collaboration
- Weekly lunch stipend and in-office meals
- Full health and dental coverage with mental health budget
- 100% parental leave top-up (6 months)
- Personal enrichment benefits

- Remote-flexible work with offices in Toronto, New York, San Francisco, London, Paris
- 6 weeks vacation (30 working days)